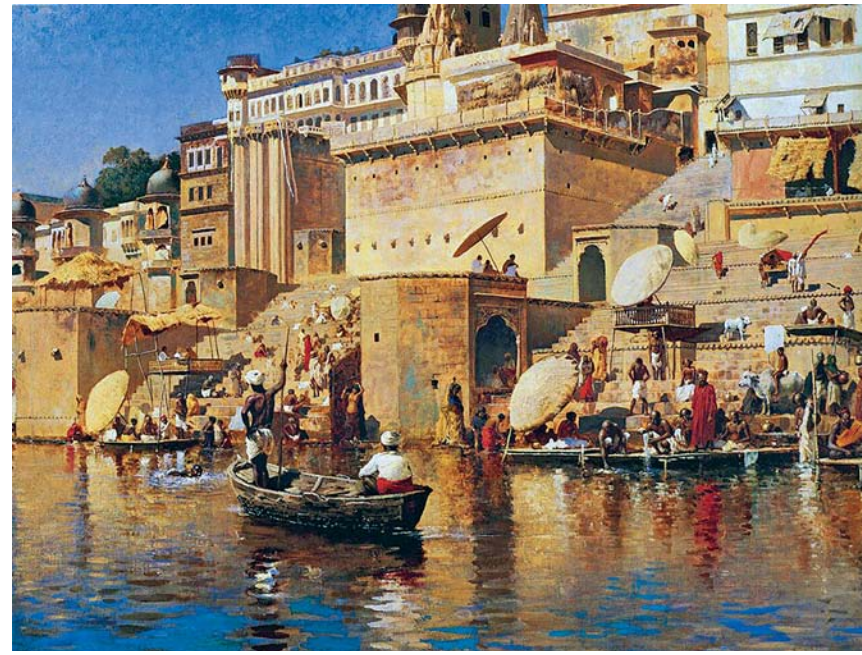


TEMPLE LAMP
Verses on Banaras
by Mirza Ghalib, translated by Maaz Bin Bilal
PENGUIN BOOKS
₹399; 110 pages



Heaven on Earth

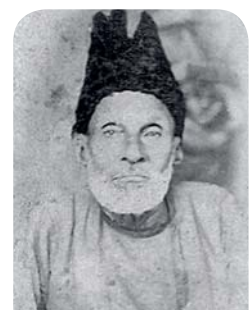
In this long poem, we see Banaras was many things for Mirza Ghalib—sanctum, paradise, trap

Mirza Ghalib, the greatest Urdu poet, apparently did not think much of Urdu and, in his mature years, wrote mostly in Persian. His Persian works, like those of other Indian poets, from Amir Khusrau to Mohammad Iqbal, remain largely unread and unsung, both here and in Persia. If a single *masnavi* by Ghalib running into 108 couplets is now and then rescued from oblivion—as it has been in an Urdu translation in 2015, a Hindi translation in 2018, and now in this English translation—this has as much to do with the felt needs of our troubled times as with the literary value of the poem.

Temple Lamp is a poem about Banaras where Ghalib stayed for a month in December 1826 on his way from Delhi to the new British capital, Calcutta. He knew no one in the city and seemed stranded there, waiting for friends in Delhi to send him money before he could resume his travels.

The poem, in its loose structure, constitutes a sort of triptych. In the first 20 verses, Ghalib complains that his friends in Delhi seem to have forgotten him: "I burn in lament...a kebab on the flame of my own song," he says (and that bathetic "kebab" comes straight from the Persian original). Having lost Delhi, he resolves to make a new "nest" in the salubrious Banaras that seems to him like *jannat*, or paradise.

Temple Lamp is a poem about Banaras, where Ghalib stayed for a month in 1826 on his way to Calcutta



In the central section of about 60 couplets, Banaras is extolled for two main reasons: its conch-blowing, idol-worshipping inhabitants are assured of deliverance from rebirth, and for the other kind of idol worshippers (*but-parast*), that is, lovers of female beauty, the city offers glimpses of ravishing unveiled women, bathing and frolicking in the Ganga. They have a god-given glow, delicate waists, graceful gait, and are in bed like Nowruz, the Persian New Year's Day that marks the beginning of spring.

But then, Ghalib wakes up and begins cursing himself for having gone "raving mad", because "to dither and delay" in Kashi was to act like a "kafir". As translator Maaz Bin Bilal puts it in his 73-page introduction, Ghalib now felt "a sense of guilt" and an urge "to break through the bonds of the city". With all its spiritual and erotic allure, Banaras seems to have been a beguiling dream. He must push on to Calcutta.

But the poem then takes another abrupt turn and ends with a self-exhortation by Ghalib towards attaining a Sufi *fanaa*-like closure: "...say Allah, and like lightning/ extinguish the rest"—including, presumably, Delhi, Banaras and himself.

Read as a poem, *Temple Lamp* is a work of deep complexity and ambivalence that is characteristic of great writers. But its simple and urgent message today is to reassert, in Bilal's words, "not just the ecumenical spirituality of Islam and Hinduism but also the cosmopolitanism of his [Ghalib's] own Persian poetry". ■

Harish Trivedi